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Peter Townsend

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

1997, 1998, 1999
Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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Interviewed by Paul Thompson

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1. Childhood roots b. 1928

P 5
Nowadays, I reflect a lot on the question of being an only child and what that means. It led, in part, to my enormous interest in family relations and extended family life, and the structure of families….

P 9
But that isolation, as a single child, and the way I would now interpret it, would be the way in which you're obliged, often, to make your own entertainment… The intensity of depending on your own resources, which I had to experience as an only child - matched by this class mixture, I think those were the two very productively creative things, as far as I was concerned.

P 7
I was born in Middlesbrough, living with my parents for about a year and a half. I was then taken by my mother to join my grandmother in Middlesbrough for another two years or so. And then, at the age of four, we all moved down - my mother, grandmother and myself - moved down to Pimlico in London, because London was the only place where she could earn a living on the stage… And after three years or so, in an upstairs flat, with a cooker on the landing, … we moved to Belsize Park, to an attic flat.

P 2
I came from a very mixed-class background in the North of England. I was born in Middlesbrough,... my mother, at the time, having just married, was living in Stockton-on-Tees with her mother, my grandmother, in Middlesbrough. And my **grandmother** was the key figure in my early life, because she was left by her husband, with three small children, in a very tiny terraced house in Middlesbrough, and she took in washing, and she rented out the two rooms upstairs, in order to get by and make a living. She was also a woman who was a kind of midwife for the local area, or, at least, worked with the midwife, and there were extraordinary tales sometimes told by my mother of going into a woman's house and finding a dead baby in a box on the shelf of the kitchen. So my grandmother came from a generation where there were large families and many early deaths. And this was near a fishing community. My grandfather's family were fisherfolk,…

P 4
My grandmother was more the sort of stable influence on me, because she provided the meals and looked after the home during the War when my mother went out to work

P 6
My grandmother was perfect, an absolute rock, in terms of emotional solidity

P 10
Moral values? I had two big influences. I've spoken about one of them here, who was my grandmother. She rang true as a bell all her life… I don't know of anybody who didn't think the same about her, not only her simplicity but her utter dependability and warmth… She worked for others all her life.

P 2
My **mother** was a great singer… And she became, in her teens, a very well-known singer in [Middlesborough] and the surroundings… She sang in lots of operettas and operas, and that actually led to her going on the stage and earning a living from it. She met my father in Stockton Amateur Dramatics Society performances and they sang together, and after she married, they had me a year or so later, and he got a job at Glasgow. Went to Glasgow ... to cut a long story short, [when I was a year and a half] my mother left him, with me, came back to join my grandmother in Middlesbrough and, in a sense, I was the child of a lone parent family, although supported very much, and more so, by a grandmother. And then we came to London, to Pimlico.

P 8
My mother was singing on the pier at Blackpool, for three months. I used to have wonderful summers, as a child, because my mother was in concert parties, one year after another, right through the thirties - Worthing, Hastings, Llandudno, Blackpool.
And through the these summers, while my mother used to be working on the pier, and my grandmother was sitting in a nearby deck-chair, I was on the sands, building sandcastles, or swimming, or going to buy ice creams, sometimes I bought as many as a dozen ice-creams, at a ½d. a go, in a day. It was a joyous life, and very self-indulgent in some ways! (LAUGHS) But terrific.

P 3
My mother's background was one of being brought up in a Middlesbrough - very nearly - a slum… She was very much like the famous Gracie Fields, and in effect, I used to think she sang better than Gracie Fields, but… when she was in London, we had a very chequered existence, because some weeks she was very much in work, and other weeks she wasn't. She tended to live on what money she had, sometimes she had two or three pounds a week from earnings, singing at Clubs and at Masonic Lodges and the Cafe Royal and so on, in London, earning ... This was in the mid-1930s…

And then in the War, at the beginning of the War, she first hit fame, or moderate fame, in a well-known musical play called New Faces, but that only lasted a few months… And then she sought work with ENSA during the War years, like Vera Lynne and others, and she toured the

country to Army barracks, she went across to France and sang to troops there, and the high point of her career came at the end of the War, when she sang in two Royal Command Performances.

But after that, like a lot of other women, she was not wanted when she reached her forties, on the stage, and she no longer got phoned up for new commissions. And she just, for a time, collapsed with that. It was a very tragic period for her, and she didn't know what to do, and became morose and depressed, and gradually, she pulled herself out of that, by getting a job with Shell, as a clerk.

P 4
And this was her during her lifetime. So you can tell she has been an enormous influence on me, because she has a huge sense of narrative and wit, and regales every audience with most extraordinarily pointed and revealing stories about past experience.
My **father**, I'd better just say, very quickly, in the First World War, he flew for the Royal Flying Corps, and … he was shot down once, and was very fortunate. He regarded that as the high point of his whole life, and it's rather sad, because he became a commercial traveller of a kind, for much of the rest of his life. He then joined up again in the Second World War. He was rather amazing, he was one of the few people who served in both World Wars as a pilot… And I didn't have much to do with him. One of these sad things about family life is sometimes that when there is a divorce, the child does not keep up with both parents in the same way, and I saw very little of him, apart from one or two visits when I was around 10 or 11. I virtually saw nothing of him until I was married, then saw very little of him, and I think, I blame myself partly for that. But in the last 10, 12 years of his life, partly through the influence of Jean, I got to know him much better, and we became very fond of each other in his final years.

2. School influences

2a. Fleet Road Elementary School

P 12
I was encouraged, thanks be to God, by people like this dear Miss Sard, who was a useful influence on me at my elementary school... to apply for various Scholarships, including Christ's Hospital and three or four other schools, including University College School…. I was one of only four [scholarship boys at UCS].

2b. University College School 1939-46

P 10-11
The other big influence, really big influence, was the Headmaster of University College School, who was a man called C.S. Walton. I know a lot of other people have felt the same about him… He was a very young Headmaster before the War, and he was there all through the War, when I was at that school. And he was an extraordinary example of a person who taught not only moral values, but a whole approach to keeping open doors on experiences. Let me give you one example of what an extraordinary person he was.

He had what he called "Commando Exams", at one point during the War. He decided that stock exams were really not very stretching, that... if you lived in the kind of home which could train

you for them, … you could perform, get the orthodox results, and get to university accordingly. But he thought that often boys, because he was teaching boys, had talents which weren't appreciated. So he devised the "Commando Exams", where, through the day, we had to indulge in a number of other activities, than all sitting in a quiet environment, writing papers…. We had to run a three-mile cross-country race around Hampstead Heath, and if we did it fast, we then had more time than everybody else to write the maths paper. But if we ran it too fast, and got so exhausted we were incapable of writing the maths paper. So we had to make some judgements about this. We had to swim two lengths of the swimming bath between exams, too. So we went for a cross-country run, we did an exam, we went in the swimming bath. And then there were two or three exams, I remember acutely, where the deliberate intention was to distract us. We were given the instruction that we had to concentrate on the paper, but we had a master at the front of the classroom acting the fool, or banging the table repeatedly with a ruler, doing everything to distract us. And so the whole idea was, how could you perform in the most trying experiences of life? …

And I naturally thought it was brilliant, because I did rather well at it, … because I used to, generally speaking, do very well at sport, and I was also quite good at concentrating when there were distractions around! (LAUGHS)

So he was a colossal influence. He also took me - I think, in retrospect, I know he had gay inclinations, but he, he exercised a kind of self-discipline about that. I didn't really appreciate that so much at the time … I remember, he took two or three of us in his car, … he took us in a Jaguar to the Surrey hills, and we sat on the top and talked about how we could change the school, as sixth formers… for a kind of Awayday, as we would call it now, to say, "Well, what's wrong with the school? What can we do to put it right?" But seriously, that's what he did, and … he taught me to think about values in a very acute way…

I was two years Captain of the School, and I like to think there were one or two innovations which were my responsibility, like the abandonment of the University Cadet Corps… We could think of better things to do, as boys! And so we did… We set up various charitable activities, raising money for ... I think it was the Royal National Institute for the Blind.

2c. Religion

P 13

Cecil Walton, he set such an example, in some senses, that he almost opened my mind to the possibilities that religion was a really important experience, and so I started going to St. Peter's Church, round the corner, in Belsize Park, and became a very committed Christian.... I became rather prudish at that stage, … I did at that stage, take the view that a lot of those around me ought to know better than they were, how they were acting. And that experience was like a little rocket in the sky that went up…

And my future wife then, Ruth, who I met at the age of 16, and we were very much in love at the age of 17, 18, her mother was a Christian Scientist. Her sister, Jennifer, who was only a year older than her, was also very much devoted to Christian Science. I became interested, I read about it, and … then there was a tragedy, because just when penicillin had been developed in 1947, Jennifer fell ill with tuberculosis, and because of the Christian Science ideology, she allowed herself, and they allowed her, to die. And she died in Wales. And I've never forgotten going to Wales in the last days of her life, and running around the, literally running around the neighbourhood, to just find something to do while others were crying in the house. And that finished Christian Science for life, for me... The encounter with the Church,… it was a very short span of about three years.

3. Army experience 1946-48

P 9

[In the War], the important thing was sociability and the way in which I, even at the age of 13, I was an Air Raid Warden, and helped shovel one or two incendiaries off the roof- tops of the street, and was sitting with mugs of tea, around the clock, into the night shift sometimes, with other people from the surrounding houses. And people met each other through hiding in air raid shelters.

And, of course, later, my Army experience. When I became 18, there was still compulsory service after the War, and I remember vividly that, in the next two beds to me, when I was doing my compulsory training in the first months at Yeovil, Somerset, to which I was recruited, the two people on either side were Geordies, who were illiterate, and where, regularly, I wrote their love letters home to Newcastle. And, of course, that was a very vivid experience of actually meeting people and … [becoming] quite familiar with the problems that they had encountered and the lives they'd experienced, and this was, I think, one of the formative experiences in my life.

P 17

But service in the Army, and trying to do some of the education courses, and teach some of the education courses, took me into an acquaintance with Bertie Russell, and the fact that he was still, in his later years, teaching at Cambridge University, and I thought, "Well, why don't I do that?"

P 18

The period in the Army was Yeovil, Blandford, and then near Glasgow, for the Royal Army Education Corps. They wanted me to go in for some officer training scheme. I did go in for it, and I did succeed. Oh, it was some great obstacle course in both physical terms as well as mental terms, and was offered a place, but I was scared stiff I would be committed to missing the first year at Cambridge, so I didn't accept.

P 19

[The Army was] an important negative experience. I learned a lot of the things about the class system, as operating through the Army. And I learned about all those skills which I didn't really, personally, want to possess… Square-bashing. Shouting, shouting, becoming a

sergeant-major, and shouting at troops, and getting them up at 5.30 in the morning. All of those sort of things.

4. Cambridge University 1948-51

4a
P 17
In fact, I was still doing the post-War arrangement, whereby you could get a degree in two years, so I got my degree on that basis in philosophy, and went on, in the third year, I opted to stay on for a third year, in order to read Part II of Social Anthropology, which I did, and I thoroughly enjoyed, and I first made my acquaintance, really, with Sociology, in a more informed and educative way, and, as it were, in some senses, but I put this is in slightly ironic quotes, "never looked back".

And the course was then called "Moral Sciences", but it consisted of elements of philosophy, logic, and social psychology and ethics, believe it or not. So those four were pillars of my first two years education.

P 18
I had, at the time, and I have now, a kind of love/hate relationship to Cambridge. It is, undoubtedly, today, the best university, in the sense of having some of the best results, in terms of research, than any university. There's absolutely no question about that… But there was the other Cambridge. And the two cities exist today, and could be, and should be brought together more than they are, in terms of more access on the part of local population to the University, for example… So I had a love/hate relationship, because at the same time as I was absorbing all the benefits of Cambridge, I knew there were others who were denied them, and those others, sometimes, were only a few streets away. And it was at the apex of the class system…

4b. Bertrand Russell
P 21-22

I was totally inspired by Bertie Russell, who, in his Emeritus years, was coming to Cambridge to lecture just once a week, on a Wednesday morning, at nine o'clock in the morning. And he had a thousand people in the hall. I was in the front row, and my future wife and I were sitting in the front row listening to him. He was inspirational too, because I was then a raw reporter on the University newspaper, called *Varsity*, and we had an amazing experience, only five or six weeks into my first year, where I was a reporter, and I was very proud of myself for reporting in the paper, one week, that Bertie Russell had been... talking about Moscow, he seemed to have been saying that the atom bomb ought to be dropped on Russia, as a possibility. And I wrote up this story…

But at the weekend, I drafted this story about what he was reported to have said, and lo and behold, on the... following Monday morning, there was I with my future wife, … in these wonderful rooms in St. John's College, just above where Wordsworth used to have rooms, just near the Great Hall, or the Hall restaurant, in the First Court, and up the stairs came some steps ... And there came a knock on the door, and in walked Bertrand Russell. And we thought, "Oh, my God!" We got in all of a fluster!

We were terribly flustered! So flustered that when Ruth asked him what coffee he would have, whether he took sugar in his coffee, he said, "None", and she tipped half the pot of sugar into the cup! … And Bertrand Russell proceeded to give me a scoop, in the sense that not only did he deny the story, but he said what really had gone on. And he cared so much about what was thought of him in his native University, that he wanted the error to be put right. So that following week, I not only had the front page headline of my own newspaper, but the story crept into a lot of the nationals too… It was an extraordinary encounter with the great man.

4c. Anthropology

P 22

I suppose I learned a bit about sociological determinism there, and the way in which the construction of societies seeped into people's thoughts, and bones, even, and accounted for some of these extraordinary variations across the world. And that was a very exciting discovery, because it made one come back to thinking about how Wartime Britain had created a different society, for example, or how post-War Britain was evolving. And that set a train of thought which has stayed with me forever.

And the anthropological method was so important. That idea that you didn't do things in an aloof way, you didn't sort of send out teams of juniors to collect your data, and you sat at home in comfortable situations and looked through your ... your microscope and wrote your reports, but you actually lived, you engaged with that society. There was a sense of you not being able to write anything decent about the societies you were trying to describe and understand, unless you at least spent part of the time there, and better, lived among them. And I think the idea that some anthropologists went and lived for several years, in very uncomfortable circumstances, sometimes in very dangerous conditions, and tried to understand the society as a whole, because they couldn't explain any detail within it, without understanding the whole. That was, that was a lesson that has lived with me all my life.

P 31-32
One excitement was feeling that Western society, our own society, deserved investigation and illumination, just as much as some of the poorer societies, which the social anthropologists had researched so industriously. That was certainly true.

But there was also the idea that [the] social anthropologist, he or she was relatively comprehensive in the idea that no particular thing could be explained, unless you explained everything, or tried to, at least, put it in an overall setting. Because the functionalist theme of social anthropology was that each piece of behaviour, each system of relationships, was functional in relation to the rest of society, and actually worked. Just as we're familiar with that idea in, in biology, we're familiar with this idea in tracing differences between the species, that patterns of behaviour are built up in order to achieve survival, and to enhance comforts and living standards. And I think that that idea - although I hesitate to use the word, "systemic" - the idea that societies are systemic, is something we find so overwhelming, that we often depart from it, and we retreat into small-scale studies. And I've noticed this all my life.

And it seemed to me, very exciting, in the early days, where we developed this at the Institute of Community Studies. Because this was directly inspired by social anthropology, that the extended family in Britain - I mean, merely the actual collective identification people have with a wider family than just parents and young children, the fact that they do reach grandparenthood and great-grandparenthood these days, and have many ramifications and connections, and are often driven by needs and duties, and obligations, which extend far wider than just the two generations of young or middle-aged parents with young children.

5. London neighbouring

P 27
When I'd got a job in London, for a time, I remember floating backwards and forwards. Ruth, with the new baby, was in Cambridge, and I was in London [staying in my mother's flat] during the early weeks and months of the Political and Economic Planning job.

Then we managed, by searching around, to find a terraced cottage on the tail end of a lease, in Hampstead, … bought the tail end of the lease for about seven years, it was, before we then managed to rake around for the loan to buy the house eventually. But that was in Coronation year. We remember that, because this was a cul-de-sac of working-class terraced cottages, which were bedecked with flags for the Coronation in 1953.

P 198—200
Being aroused politically, is a memory that crops up repeatedly, that affects one's life, and even what we do. And I mean by that, living in an area where it was literally true that there were people of wealth as well as professional class, but also manual labourers, and newly-arrived immigrants from the Caribbean. This we luxuriated in, in a way. We knew we were lucky that we had around us, within very short distances, people of every class and age…

We were seized by it, but also endeavoured to respond. We didn't want to regard this as sort

of artificial. It wasn't passing your neighbour by. There were a number of neighbours in each class who we got to know extraordinarily well, and as a consequence, were aroused by political ill-treatment. I mean, this arose with a newspaper man who was badly treated by the Social Services. It arose from the terminal illness of another… A man locally, only again a hundred yards, 150 yards away, an old man, I think he was then 75ish, 78ish, that kind of age, who lived in appalling circumstances, who we visited repeatedly, got his shopping, and to our dismay, was found dead with his ginger cat on his chest. And the way in which that had happened was like touching a raw nerve…

It arose through the treatment of Irish immigrants, because the woman who worked with us, helped us with the huge amount of washing for such a large family, was Irish, and brought us into touch with a lot of the events that were happening to the Irish in Camden Town. So there was a sense in which our ordinary domestic and neighbourhood life fuelled our interest in politics, but also was fuelled by politics itself, with events outside which impinged on their lives. And that was a fantastic asset…

<u>It's almost like you were living out the ideal of the extended family and involvement with neighbours that you also saw in Bethnal Green.</u>

I think that was partly conscious. Some of it was unconscious…

<u>6. Political and Economic Planning 1952-4</u>

Early interviewing
P 27-28
I was at Political and Economic Planning, and my job, really, was to produce research pamphlets… The very first pamphlet I did, was called, "Poverty: Ten Years After Beveridge", and that actually appeared in 1952. And the second thing I did, which was equally important, was that I went to Lancashire, in a recession in the cotton industry, and visited several of the cotton towns and interviewed unemployed, mainly men, and visited the various Employment Exchanges, as they were then called, to talk to people in the queues, waiting for Unemployment Benefit. And this was a very deep and absorbing experience.

Because I went to places like Nelson and Rochdale, and Oldham, and I tended to get bed and breakfast at local pubs when I could, and I remember, at Nelson, being woken up at 4.30, I think it was, or 5 in the morning, with the clatter of clogs on the cobbled streets… The clatter symbolised the collectiveness of working-class life, in many respects. I'd seen in it in the docks in London, when you can easily get to a meeting, or could do, in those earlier days, in the forties and fifties, for 10,000, 5,000 men. And similarly, in other parts of Britain, you had these experiences of many working-class people getting up at the same hour, trailing to the factories, to settle into work. And, of course, there were many hands plying their way at the spinning wheels and the machines generally. And I remember seeing some of them where they were, literally, using, in the early 1950s, machines that had actually been installed in 1840. And I haven't forgotten that particular experience, because it just reminded me of the sheer boredom, but also drudgery, and extreme physical stress of working like that for, well, ten hours, often, a day.

(See Peter Townsend, `A society for people', in Norman Mackenzie (ed.) *Conviction*, London: McGibbon and Kee, 1958, pp 93-120: on his first interview –
`The first address I had chosen at random proved to be a dark, terraced house and I remember the whitened doorstep and the tall chimneys rising above the roofs in the distance. Twice my courage failed me and I walked past without knocking… [Eventually] I knocked hesitantly and when the door opened explained myself rather abjectly to a woman in heer early twenties. She was friendly…Somehow she patiently coached me through my interview, tactfully answering the really important questions which it had not occurred to me to ask' (p 105).)

7. Institute of Community Studies 1954-57

P 43-44
Well, I met Michael Young during this period, and he had been, first of all,... working with the Labour Party on it's manifesto. But then finding that his interests were other than in politics, and more in creative ideas for new organisations. And one of those organisations he had the bright idea about, was launching the Institute of Community Studies. And I was involved in that in the very early days, when we were just drawing up applications for research money... And we all got excited about investigating the extended family, and that was what I thought was the major purpose of the Institute of Community Studies.

When it turned out, three years afterwards, that it wasn't the major purpose, as I understood it, I was less attracted to doing it. I was also less attracted, because Michael and I had different views about writing up a text, and what it should convey, and he did me the service of editing my first drafts of the old people, enormously, but had the courtesy and the strength of mind to allow me to have the last word, and I'm afraid, I didn't accept a lot of the, as I saw it, journalese that he was attempting to impose…

And I felt I could learn more, at that stage, from association with Richard Titmuss. That was undoubtedly true, and my great friend, Brian Abel-Smith had already joined him. .. I decided that's what I wanted to confirm, and join Richard to do more of, and got the chance to go to LSE as Research Fellow cum Lecturer. And it was I who applied for money, to go to LSE, under the auspices of the Nuffield Foundation, to write *The Last Refuge*, which was the book on old people's Homes…

8. The Family Life of Old People

8a. Sampling

P 32-34
It's worth my giving the example I often have used with students and others. It's what happens when you do a random social survey, and which is why it's important to do a random social survey, by random sampling.... Perhaps it's worth explaining quickly. We devised the idea, at the Institute of Community Studies, that Peter Wilmott would look at young children, that Michael Young would look at the middle-aged, and I would look at the elderly. As it happened, without going into the reasons, Michael and Peter joined forces, and wrote *Family and Kinship in*

East London, I completed the job on old people. But in both cases, in all the work that we did, we found that, by sampling, and then by interviewing, we were able to contribute something quite fresh to British knowledge about family life.

Now, sampling could be done in different ways. One way of doing it is simply taking a list of household addresses, and going to visit, say, every 20th house, or address. Another way is - which I found I had to do, I wanted to get hold of old people, and, of course, if you just went to houses or flats, you'd have - two-thirds or three-quarters of them would be pointless, because there'd be no old person living there, and it would cost a lot and waste a lot of time and energy. So the way we tried to do it, … we worked through general practitioners' lists. I went to, I think it was eight or nine, or ten general practitioners, requested, courteously, access to their medical cards, and just simply went through at an appropriate interval, every 30th card, or whatever And that's how I collected a list of 200 old people to go and see in Bethnal Green and surrounding streets. But … in a representative sample of that kind, you do get extraordinary differences across the continuum from one person to another. It's not just in age, it's also in family living.

At one extreme was, I think I can say their name now, the Agombars, who, as I remember it, they had nine or ten surviving sons and daughters, all living in the surrounding streets, with their children. The Agombars, there were one or two grandchildren around, and a few great-grandchildren around too, and they lived in a house with an aviary in the back garden - like Club Row. They had birds in cages, and every time I went to that house, and I made it my business to go to the house quite often, because it was so intriguing, I never caught the Agombars alone. There was always two, three, four, five, six other people among the family there, and usually sitting around, when I was there, at least, and getting mugs of tea, with sterilised milk, I may say, which I wasn't too partial about! And slabs of bread pudding, given from the oven. And we'd sit around, and the interview, I could never conduct it in a kind of formal, officious way. It was like a joking relationship, that, you know, everybody was making - had great mocking fun of almost every question I asked! So, interpretation, even though many of the responses were rich in information, they were often also rich in humour and witticisms…

But it was like meeting a tribe, because they had, literally, something like 80, 90, 100 related people in the surrounding streets, who had differential relationships among and with each other. And there were then outings from the pub ... pub outings, where the whole extended family would go. I got to collect **photographs** from those who'd emigrated to America, joining up with those who'd been left behind in East London, … the photos I was able to derive from local newspapers, with two coachloads of people, consisting of 80 or 100 individuals, all in one photo, all related to each other. And it was rather like social anthropologists going visiting the Indians in Latin America, and taking a photograph of the entire tribe in the village!

Now, yes, that can be exaggerated and overdone, but there is absolutely no doubt, whatsoever, that a great deal of life in Bethnal Green was governed by that kind of experience of extended family relations…

But at the other extreme from that couple,... was a single woman, who was the only daughter of an only child, and she lived in a fourth floor room, it was hardly a flat, in a set of industrial

dwellings, which were quite familiar in the East End of London… She lived in this single room, I've never forgotten her, because when I first interviewed her, I didn't really believe what I obtained from her, in terms of information, because she was, as I say, an only child of an only child. Her mother had died 30 years previously, so she'd apparently lived on her own, she'd had nothing to do with her father, or he'd died when she was a baby. She was a spinster, she seemed to have no relative. And the only person she appeared to have anything to do with, was a neighbour, three or four doors along, who, perhaps, once a fortnight, rather than even once a week, exchanged words with her on the landing, about whether one or the other would get the other a bit of shopping.

They did a little bit of exchange of that kind. But that was the only real contact. This woman went to the local library to look at the newspaper, it was a bit of a routine. A lot of people living alone, who are elderly, and who feel very constrained, especially women, because of gender differences, gender inequalities, they do live extraordinarily constrained lives. And she had a mandolin, she had a single iron-frame bed, and she had a mandolin under the bed, and which she occasionally took out, and once she took it out and demonstrated to me this was one way in which she filled her time, and entertained herself.

But it was an extraordinarily restricted life, not very much more than what we would regard as the experience of imprisonment. And I deliberately went back several times to try to get to know her, and she enjoyed those visits, I know. But, particularly, I'll never forget going to see her on one Christmas Eve, I think I took her a box of biscuits, and the only sign of Christmas was a piece of Woolworth's wrapping paper, Christmas wrapping paper, stuck up over the mantel-piece.

8b. Gender

P 47

I was, perhaps, more enthusiastic about working-class culture, and certainly I was aware of the strengths which survive to this day, and there are those enormous strengths of self-capacity. But equally, I think there were certain oppressive qualities about extended family existence, for example, certain oppressive factors about male domination, in terms of gender,... these things we were, perhaps, less sensitive to, and looking for, conscious of the importance of, than maybe people are today.

8c. Participant observation and interviewing

P 36-39

Participative observation is certainly a great deal of it, because, I mean, let me give you a good example of the method, why participative observation is so crucial in many enquiries. If you did the design of a questionnaire on paper, you say you think you want to raise this matter, this matter, and that matter, there is a sense in which you don't know beforehand, before, unless you actually go through that experience with the person you're supposed to be interviewing, you don't know what their priorities are. They may not put the matter in your order of one, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine, ten. They may start with nine, and go to six, and so on, in terms of their priorities, of what captures their interest, and their involvement, and their enthusiasm, and what they regard as important. I mean, you may be asking some people about

housing, or I may be asking some people about housing, and they keep harping on about disability. And you suddenly realise, "My God, I haven't got any questions about disability in my questionnaire!"

Now, participative observation actually communicates some sense of order into the way in which you can describe society and it's relationships... You may disagree with all the people you meet, if they think the most important thing in life is money, for example, you may think, "Oh God, I don't agree with that, because they plainly act otherwise". And then you get very interested in the question of opinion being different from, or supportive, of behaviour. All of us can ask people, what would happen if you had your income chopped in half? And you can give the answers. But that's not to say exactly how it will happen. Many people whose incomes are chopped in half, they will say, oh, they'll give up going to the cinema, or they'll not pay the TV licence, or something which they will sensitively understand is a more conventional response of what people are expected to do. In fact, of course, they'll keep up luxuries and often forego what we would regard as necessities of life, like renewing a pair of shoes, or even giving up on certain foods, foodstuffs, rather than give up what they call "life's enjoyments". Which... redirects your attention into the word "necessity".

So what I'm saying is, to get back to it, participative observation allows you to get the kind of sense of priorities as people regard them. And participative observation also allows you to observe, more objectively, behaviour, which also gives you another sense of priorities, and which is very important as a corrective to the original assumptions you take to the study. So I find that kind of thing quite important.

And finally, just to say the range of work, I mean, it's evident from the way I'm reacting, and the benefit I've gained from social anthropology, that one method cannot possibly give you all the answers. If you can indulge in others, so much the better. For me, being able to talk to, in my first piece of major work, talk to the general practitioners who gave me access to the cards of the old people's addresses, that was quite significant, because they saw old age rather differently… And for me to actually visit, because I did go with the Agombars to the funeral of a brother, was an extraordinarily revealing experience.

What I'm trying to say is that it's often a very wise thing, when you embark on a research study, yes, to choose the main instrument, that may be a questionnaire, but to complement it with other methods which you know will, indeed, complement it. In the case of the old people I was just describing, it was very important for me, not merely to go and do most, as it turned out, of the interviewing myself… But I deliberately didn't... attach as much importance to pre-coding as some other people have since, but knew that there was a sense in which it was important to record some of the things people said, and then to code accordingly, on the basis of what they told you, rather than just ask them for one of three or four selected alternatives, in a language which they couldn't do anything about, because you gave it to them. It's extraordinarily difficult to adopt a universal language, a universal terminology, and so I tended to use what is best described now as an open interview schedule.

But having done that, also to recognise that one of the methodologies was to try and write out, or

type up each interview as it was done. Because not only was I able to remember certain things which I didn't have time to record, but also to select and order it in a way which would easily be accessible afterwards. Everybody knows that if you just simply type up a recording, not only is it almost impossible to read, but it all happens in a somewhat haphazard order, and it's very difficult finding the key themes that you then want to analyse and write up subsequently. And therefore, as we did, we rearranged the interview into a certain order… If you describe the interview, you can simply follow the order you want, so that you can find it accessible for writing up purposes later on. .. I also cut out bits from the typescript copy, which I put in particular envelopes for recovery when I got to those chapters. And I found that that's time-saving too…

Another important thing which I felt was, yes, it was minor in relation to the whole study, but getting ten old people to keep a **diary**, and going through the business of trying to persuade and coax them, because that's what it came to, into doing that for seven days, was enormously revealing…

Were you keeping an ethnographic field-work diary yourself, or not?

I wish I had been. I didn't have time…

Then when you went to the interview, when you were sitting there, did you have this interview schedule there, or were you doing it all from memory?

Oh no. I think it's quite important that people ...

So once the interview was over… did you expand the notes that you'd taken, so the typescript was partly from notes at the time, but partly from what you put in afterwards?

Oh yes, I think - I think, like a lot of people, I have a good, very short-term memory. I mean, if you go and do an interview in the afternoon, and come back in the evening, and dictate it straightaway, not only do you manage to iron out the hesitations, and the blurs, and the half-finished sentences and so on, but you do recapture some of the ways they said it. I know it's not perfect, but you get very close to it, and actually ... some of the key statements and events, you certainly record in, I think, a reliable way.

8d. Giving voice and quoting
P 40-41
Did you think of using a tape-recorder at that point?

I did, and I did use it. I've still got a few tapes of some of the most interesting people I went to. Very vivid.

Do you mean you'd go back to them with a tape-recorder, because you thought they were special?

Yes. I think, at that stage, tape-recorders were pretty novel. They weren't all that good in the way they worked, and, indeed, since then, it's been ...

I've probably got a dozen recordings, covering, perhaps, 15, 20 hours of recorded interviewing. But it was subsequent to the main thing, partly done because I had the intention of doing a chapter or two on changes over two or three generations, because I was speaking to elderly people in the mid-1950s…

<u>But I think it's fair to say that you had a feeling for wanting to give a voice to the people, because I remember you having that attitude.</u>

Yes.

And so, in a way, its quite interesting that you didn't use a tape-recorder, and I don't think anybody doing your kind of work, was using one then.

Of course, it's very difficult to do it. I mean, it's an easy thing to do, in a sense, you think you've got it all on tape, and you have. But, my God, if you get back home, and you've done a hundred interviews, and you've got 500 hours of tape, or 300 hours of tape, the problem of selection is fantastic, without taking up the same amount of time looking for the things that you wanted, and then having to re-repeat them…

Now, is it true that you wanted their voices to be heard? That, when you present the book, for instance, the people come out as individuals saying things in words, don't they?

Oh yes.

Where do you think you got that idea from?

That's perceptive of you to note that. And one of the things that struck me, and I'm not sure I did it all that well, it's difficult to convey, is that I was struck by the fact that when people gave quotations in books, from interviews, much turns on how you weigh the importance of that, in terms of who said it, and in what circumstances, and what kind of person they were. And so I adopted the technique of feeling that it would be better to have fewer quotations, instead of having two or three lines every so often, let's say, to have a longer passage, but to precede that with three or four lines, which made it absolutely crystal clear to the reader, what kind of person was saying this, from the sample that you'd interviewed.

It's not easy to convey whether this is typical of the opinions that were expressed, or the experiences people had, I agree. And that is sometimes left, in effect, to the author to convey, and the reader takes time to decide how reliable it is. I often had criticisms, subsequently, of this method, because people said, "Oh well, he just picked out those things he wanted to illustrate, and, therefore, he got very biased". But then, frankly, that's true of almost every method that you adopt, because you still have to select. It's true of statistical stuff, and we all know that even collecting quantitative answers about behaviour, rather than even opinion, the way the question is framed, the way it's pre-classified, the way it's coded, what you do about "don't knows", what you've done about people who haven't answered the questions in the first place, these are all highly significant questions, in terms of how you interpret the statistical results that you're presented with.

8e. Photographs
P 39-40
Did you take photographs?

I took some in the streets, yes.... I only wish I'd taken a lot more, may I say… I deliberately went round and tried to take some photographs, which I then submitted to Routledge, the publisher, in

the hope that they would include 16 or 32 pages of photos. But they said that was going to cost them too much, and they ruled it out. And I now think, I'm talking now in 1997, I think that, quite frankly, if that book were to be ever re-issued, I'd love those photos to be included. I've still got them. And, of course, they're much more interesting now. Because, for example, a common feature of ordinary street life at the time, was not only the way in which people stood outside their doors, leaning on their brushes, and women with aprons on, scrubbing their steps, or cleaning their windows, talking to each other in neighbouring terraced houses, but there were things like the "little mothers" wheeling the pram, the "little mother" being the eldest daughter in a family of, say, 12, 13: and because there was still, then, many families of three, four, five, six in them, it was quite common for the eldest daughter, reaching her teens, to then be a kind of mother substitute in certain key activities, like looking after the baby, and wheeling it to the shops, and even dressing the baby indoors. But they took a terrific pride in showing them off to their fellow pupils, or fellow girls, their friends in the surrounding streets, or at school. "This is my baby", there was a great deal of status in that. It's very much a status symbol, the pram was, in those days - it was a carriage, rather than a pram, and often built in chrome, and cost a small fortune in working-class wages at the time, but was one of those symbols of display, which working-class mothers sought after.

9. Katherine Buildings

An old ledger as an archival starting point

P 34-35

In 1957, before I left the Institute of Community Studies in Bethnal Green, I went to an extraordinary block of industrial dwellings, overlooking the Royal Mint in Stepney. And why I went there was, that I came across the rich discovery that Beatrice Webb, when she was working with Octavia Hill, was a housing visitor to this very block. I discovered, through a manuscript which was a ledger, which she'd filled in, and the person who followed in her footsteps, as housing visitor collecting rents, but also the deliberate purpose was not merely to collect the rent, but to try and be kind of moral social workers, which was the going thing at the time, and try to advise women, especially, how to bring up their families better, and to avoid problems, and how to deal with husbands who were becoming drunkards and all the rest of it. And Beatrice Webb kept the diary in 1886, and her successor was Ella Pyecroft, who kept it for a further two years. And I came across this ledger which they'd both kept, which was caught up in some of the other papers that had been left on behalf of Beatrice Webb, or Sidney Webb, at the London School of Economics. And [I] had the bright idea to go back to the same building, and try and interview the successors.

When I went there, and I went to all 147 rooms, I think it was 147, something of that order, 150 ... and I visited every one, and was fascinated. And why it was important in relation to confirming the Bethnal Green experience was, of course, that a third of the people, or more maybe, were living the kind of extended family relations which I've described in Bethnal Green, to the hilt, and depended on each other of the three generations. But there were, at the other extreme, a number of isolated individuals. I remember clearly, a seaman who, for instance, had been in the Merchant Navy, and spent most of his life in Rio de Janeiro and Brazil, or on the high seas, and had just come to live out his old age, and he had no contacts whatsoever, and no

relatives whatsoever. And you got old lags from prison, who'd been in jail for 20, 30, 40 years, there were those sort of people there too. And this became fascinating.

There were ex-prostitutes who'd somehow survived, and made some kind of comfortable small-scale existence for themselves in their dotage. And people who had been left high and dry by bereavement, on the one hand, and high and dry by the sheer experiences of an industrial market society. And sometimes those, there would be disabled people among them who'd been left, there were women who'd been left, or men who'd - let's say, been thrown out elsewhere…

P 90
So you have a mixture of the hopeful and the hopeless. Those on their way up included… the retention of a dense pattern of familial networks of the extended family, because within that same building there were several brothers and sisters. So part of the pattern that one has to describe is that in this place there are three, four, five households which are connected, and they have almost daily contact with each other. At that time, they were still using launderettes and local authority washing rooms for laundry, and they'd go out and they'd use that together, and do jobs, exchanges for each other, reciprocal services, looking after small children on the part of grandmothers while the daughters went out to do a part-time job, etc. That kind of sociability contrasted vividly with the isolates, who were much more numerous in that sort of setting, than they are generally in society at large…

P 35
You got that kind of extraordinary range and mixture. And yet, imposed upon it, was this kind of collective industrial dwelling experience. There was a kind of collective neighbourliness, in a sense, which was also very valuable… The building was not taken down until quite late, until as far as I know, either the late sixties or early seventies. But Katherine Buildings, as it was called, was also a very formative experience, in terms of the extended family.

10. LSE 1957-63

P 50-51
The Department of Social Science and Administration was beginning to bubble, if that's the right word, intellectually. The Department of Sociology at LSE, I discovered, was really rather set in a narrow mould, and was somewhat impervious to the ways in which policy, social policy in particular, acted as cause of structural changes, and it seemed to be that they'd accepted part of the American distinction between sociology and social work... They talked of it as an applied science, etc.. And to this day, there are these problems to do with sociology in not embracing a sufficiently active and mobile and dynamic view about the causes of developments within society, and the structures which lie behind a lot of individual behaviour and relationships…

But at that time, going back to the late fifties, LSE was, undoubtedly, as a Department of Sociology, in the van. I mean, it virtually had a monopoly of the development of sociology in Britain. Sociology was slow to develop. It was in its infancy.. But at that time, also, and this, I think has attracted even more notice, the Department of Social Science and Social Administration got a new lease of life when Richard Titmuss was appointed in 1950, … as the

Head of the Department. It was, as I say, a place which inspired me, and I chose to go and work as a kind of apprentice with Richard Titmuss; but also because Brian Abel-Smith was a very close friend, and we'd already been working together on some research.

11. The Last Refuge (1957-61)

11a. Piloting and sampling

P 70-71

I was in Bethnal Green and got interested in following up … the kind of help that older people began to need when they became infirm. The question was very much, how far was it reasonable to expect family to do this? How far did they increasingly have to turn to either local or institutional services, to manage? And while I was in Bethnal Green, I happened to spend a relatively short amount of time, but I did make it my business to go to two places which really sparked off the later research, and these two places were St. Matthew's Hospital, which was a geriatric hospital, … where I spent a few days simply going through their records … trying to find out from the hospital records how many of them had close family and how many did not. I then did the same at a residential institution… It was called Southern Grove. And I visited this place for three or four days too, and talked to the then warden…

Although those two experiences were very brief, they supported some of the themes in the study of people living in their own homes, because it showed that there was a very strong correlation between your chances of ending up in either a geriatric hospital or a residential Home, and whether you had close family or not, and particularly whether you had a daughter available in or near your home… That was the personal experience which sparked off the commitment really, to do the national research.

What we then did was, we embarked on a national study. It was the first random sample of institutions to be taken and to be visited and information collected, in order to be able to generalise about what was going on nationally in a major set of institutions… What we did was to visit, I believe it was altogether around 180 institutions and Homes, and these, of course, ranged from enormous old institutions like Luxborough Lodge near Baker Street at the time, which housed a thousand people, 1100 I think it was at the time. And there were other very big ones in London too. And right through to tiny private residential Homes for only four or six registered residents.

P 79

[We showed that] it was also possible to do it in a way which could be representative of them. Because, obviously, in the very large places, with a thousand people, you couldn't talk to a great many people, whereas when you get to a private Home of only six people, you needed, really, to see at least two or three of them anyway, half of them. So we varied the number of interviews according to size of Home, but in a way which was still, that would still allow us to, with the weighting, we could get back to representativeness in the first place. In other words, we varied the number of people we talked to, deliberately, in order to be representative of both the large and small places. So that aspect of the methodology is quite important.

11b. Fieldwork: visiting homes

P 72-78

The differences were remarkable. I tried to convey them in photographs in the book… At the time, Chief Welfare Officers were in charge of the local authorities and, beforehand, I'd written to all of those in the areas where I'd drawn for sampling and visiting, the list of residential Homes.

So… the first step was to go to the Chief Welfare Officer in his office, and to cross-examine him, interview him - usually it was him, very rarely at that time was it a her -about all the residential institutions under his management, and to hear his side of the developments that were taking place, and what progress was being made since the passage of the National Assistance Act in 1948, in terms of trying to get rid of the old Poor Law institutions and replace them with more homely, smaller, residential Homes.

That was the purpose of the 1947 legislation, and why I was provoked to go and look at it was that, here we were at that time, more than ten years on from the Act, and here were all these Poor Law institutions still around, where people were still being cared for. And part of my concern was to try and, from that initial visit in Stepney, part of my concern was to try and find how common that experience was, and why it still existed when the plan was to get rid of these places. …

But the average, I think, was about two hours and I tried to take notes, and then write it up, it got typed up afterwards, about all aspects of how many Homes they had, what types they were, how many people lived in them. And the other deputies furnished us with lots of paper, of course, about these places, and what was planned, and which were new, and which had difficulties, and problems of staffing, and problems of admission and how it related to local services. All kinds of things I asked there.

Then I went on, from that, by arrangement, to visit the Home itself. And I tried to let them know in advance quite what the scope of the work would be. And in the average case… I would go to, usually on the outskirts of the town, to a converted mansion or large house, which during the War and immediate post-War years, was not very saleable, and which local authorities had acquired because it was cheaper than building fresh, and which they converted for use by, let us say, 20, 30, 40 or more elderly residents. And some of these places were very pleasant; but often they were at the end of a long drive, and therefore, extraordinarily difficult for residents to have any local life like they might have done in their previous homes, of popping out into the street to the local shop 50 yards away. They couldn't do this. And this was a great constraint on their capacity for having external social relations, or even having visitors. So one builds a picture of quite a number of these places being rather isolated, and people themselves being even more isolated within them, and yet having the relative comforts, but they were rationed in terms of their personal possessions, and what articles they could, let's say, decorate the room with. Extraordinarily limited.

It was rather carrying over the impression of how it would be convenient for the staff to run something close to an army barracks. I think this conveys the right impression to somebody

coming fresh into them, how relatively tidy, how lacking they were in ordinary home facilities - furnishings and cushions and carpets, and the availability of hot water bottles, and all the rest of it. And that was the average experience…

It wasn't accepted or revealed, but there was a very dependent relationship imposed upon the elderly, by virtue of the fact that the staff expected to do things, they didn't expect residents to do much for themselves, even when, as I found, a number of them were reasonably active, and could have washed up for themselves, made themselves cups of tea, pottered about in a home from room to room, and perhaps sat with friends in their own bedrooms. People were discouraged from entertaining in their own bedrooms… So the sociability was very restricted of people, and they were very dependent, a feeling that, you know, all they could do was sit and gawp at the television, or sit, as so many did, around the walls of the room, to have a good view of what was going on, and not be looked over their shoulder, or feel that they were being stared at by people. There was this very common feature.

Another fascinating thing which I learned, which only came up really by chance, because our purpose was, after seeing the Chief Welfare Officer, was to go and get an inventory of a kind. … The rooms people want to show you when you're on a kind of royal visit, are not the rooms where some of the most incapacitated residents, and where there's water coming in the roof, you won't be shown those bits of the institution. And, of course, I frequently discovered when I … said, "Oh, I'm awfully sorry, but I'm supposed to check on all the beds in this particular place, I find that I'm 20 short. Where are these? Is it that your records are wrong?" And then I would find some miserable attic, or some miserable temporary erected room on the margins of the Home, which people were really rather embarrassed about and ashamed of, because this was one annexe which was never heated enough, was too wet, or they tended to put some of the most difficult of their residents, who shouted a lot, or were incontinent.

I then realised that this structural business in the Home was related to the residents, because part of our object was not only to take a kind of inventory of the Home and to talk to some of the staff, but to actually interview all the recent residents, those who'd recently entered. We devised that because we wanted not merely to get an idea of how people viewed the institutions, we also wanted to know their reasons for coming there, and we felt we were unlikely to get good answers from people who'd been there two, three or more years, because they would have forgotten the reasons for coming there, it would be less fresh in their minds, and to give the new residents, as it were, the priority of attention, would also reveal much more about the kind of circumstances into which they were expected to fit….

Of course, when you think about it, those residents who have become friendly with the staff, who have been there a long time, tend to get certain privileges, like rewards…. And that means, of course, one of the interesting things about the new resident is, of course, that they are often in a state of shock in their arrival, and yet the way the Home operates, to the convenience of the Matron and the staff, is really in the interests of the longest-established residents who are most compliant. Therefore, the new residents find themselves in the worst physical situation in the Home, that they are the ones who are given the bed nearest the draughty door, they are the ones who get the seats furthest from the television set. I'm trying to give some kind of impression of

what it was like at that time, to go to a standard residential Home.

But at the extremes, … the situation was very different in an old Poor Law institution for, let us say, 500 people, or a thousand people, compared with a private residential Home, usually in a seaside town like Eastbourne, … where there might be only half a dozen or ten residents at most.

If you take the big institution first, that tended to correspond with my initial experience in going to Southern Grove in Stepney…. It was a very daunting experience. It was really quite a shocking experience….

One went into this rather gaunt, vast place, busy .- there were the noises of trolleys being pushed backwards and forwards, there were stone passages, stone slabs on the floors. There was little carpeting anywhere, there were mainly bare boards in the dormitories and the dining rooms. People were congregated in large numbers. You went into a day room, as they were called, and there might be 20, 30, 40, 50 people on Windsor chairs - wooden chairs usually with arms - arranged around the walls, sometimes with an old, I think it was then still black and white television, at a distance where, of course, many people without good sight couldn't possibly see it beyond about 10 or 20 feet.

They were often just sitting rocking themselves, rocking to and fro, very little conversation. Again, one needs to understand the situation to explain it. Carpet slippers the women wore, flowered aprons. The men usually had tweed jackets, stained and poor quality woollen trousers, often caps on indoors. Many people with spectacles that were tied together with string. People with chipped mugs. …

That kind of dragooned mass warehousing situation, was very shocking to a youngster like myself, who hadn't witnessed it before. And the arrogance, as I remember it, of the Warden in charge. He had a lofty flat which was, I must say, very spacious, very comfortably appointed, and where he could look out on the squares below, which were supposed to be almost the exercise yards of the past, of the workhouse, where people were allowed to wander out from a day room into the yard, and he could look down on them. And he was very arrogant about [how] they were caring for these people, and you couldn't expect much of them, but they were doing a wonderful job…

Between the staff and the residents there was almost a class situation, a polarised situation, where the staff, even when they got relatively modest salaries, because they did, were able to exercise a kind of control over very weak and infirm people, which they shouldn't have been allowed to do in those circumstances. And in case this is thought to be exaggerated, I have to point out, and it exists today in prisons and many other institutions, up to a point, that the staff had control over pocket money, and whether certain residents were capable of receiving it or not…

It meant that the power of whether certain monies could be conferred, even to get cigarettes or sweets, or a birthday card for a grandchild, all of that, people knew they had to do what the

management suggested was the right and proper thing, so far as they were concerned, in their behaviour. …

For there was a kind of attitude of tending to exaggerate the infirmities of the people inside these institutions, on the part of staff. As part of their work it was more convenient, frankly, to shepherd people in regular lines through the bathroom, one after the other, than to give up the much greater amount of time to just sitting with an elderly person who would prefer to do it on their own… The result of that was to stunt people's activities, and to reduce them to virtually nothing, or very little. They had very little opportunity to get out and about… On the whole, staff discouraged many people from going out at all. On the grounds, "Oh well, you might fall over Mrs. X, and hurt yourself' … Well, about a quarter of the people in the entire country, who were living in residential Homes, were living in these type of institutions….

On the whole, the most sensitive behaviour from staff and the most comfortable experiences of residents were to be found in the voluntary Homes… But at the other extreme, which was more common, were the disastrous private Homes for four, six, eight people, where the people were sometimes in a state almost of terror of the Matron, who ruled the roost, who decided how everything happened. She had only three or four staff and she made profits, and her object was really to run the most profitable establishment. And you got sometimes people being fed almost nothing: trays in their rooms, they were even more isolated, they didn't really have any contact with each other. They had single rooms, yes, but it was almost like a small prison.

11c. Participant observation

P 87-88

I worked in a former Public Assistance institution, a former workhouse, called "Newholme" in Manchester. I may say, and believe me, it was neither new nor a home! But the most vivid experience was - I kept a diary … a diary of my operating as a bath attendant… I was having to work in Newholme for three or four day. Newholme … was a little more recently built from the 19th century than some of the others, and I did the usual thing of going round every part of it, and then trying to interview some of the new residents… Well, all of that took about three days. [But] I stayed on several more days and used the opportunity, like the good social anthropologist, of being around when I wasn't expected to be… I think that's an extraordinarily important thing for any research done in such places, that you have to allow for the ordinary events going on in these places, and not at times chosen for what I've described as royal visits or the hour or two set aside by the management for some research worker or dignitary to come looking around, to be satisfied that all is well. So I had a dual purpose.

I think sometimes that some of the research we did in those days, I was allowed access to doing things which I now wonder whether my successors would be able to do the same. I doubt it. I think that people are now more used to investigative journalism, as well as investigative research, and I suspect that the bureaucracies and the government are now trying to screen off some of those types of investigation.

However, I was in Newholme, in Manchester, …and my job, after doing all these various interviews around the Home, I then became an attendant, looking after the bathing of the old

men. And I think what forced itself upon my consciousness was a number of things.

One was the extraordinarily kind of - abject passivity of some of these elderly men. It was almost as if the process of institutionalisation had forced upon them how to behave, and how to be, as it were, preserve their integrity only within - it's almost like the ways in which we have fantasies, we have an inside life and we have an external life, and some of them communicated this by talking a bit about their past and about what their feelings were for their loved ones. And mostly it was feelings of being bereft and being abandoned. But it was also feelings of being neglected by staff, who didn't want to know, and didn't have any forms of communication. It was almost as if they were - I know it's not, it wasn't a situation where they were like in a solitary confinement or in a prison where the doors were locked at such and such hours, and you were only let out at such and such hours, but they led a routine which was amazingly limited.

That aspect of their demeanour and their behaviour, I think, was terribly important, and although this was only the one experience, it obviously then got related by me to all kinds of other interviews I'd had across the country, and helped to inform those interviews and the experiences other people touched upon.

But it was also physically the problem of seeing these very thin, many thin characters, how gentle one had to be to get them into the bath, how careful one had to be in using one's elbow to make sure the water wasn't too hot, how little they had in the way of personal belongings, how the underpants they had, the kind of combinations they were wearing, sometimes had six, seven, eight, ten laundry marks, or tabs attached, which almost underlined their loss of identity. They were just numbers in an institution where they didn't even possess underpants of their own, which they took off. And that was in many ways - although it isn't like, you know, some of the terrible experiences people recount about refugee camps and somebody who suddenly comes in smashes somebody to death - yes, it's not as extreme as all that, but it's equally disconcerting and devastating to absorb what the process of institutionalisation had done to people, without them having any means of fighting back. Yes, of course there were those characters, some of them had enormous resources in terms of personality, but they'd turned it inwards, in order to - oh, I don't know, make sure that they got another slice of toast at breakfast. It was conforming.

They knew that conformity was the order of the day. And that was a terrible fact to learn in a place where we were supposed to be indulgent towards the physically infirm and disabled. It was the old tradition of the workhouse was to be strict and punitive towards the undeserving poor, but to be indulgent towards the deserving poor. And this tradition was supposed to be maintained.

What I was discovering was that the tradition of being indulgent towards the deserving poor was not put into effect, because the other side of the workhouse story, the punitive discipline, was really ruling the roost, because you can't have staff behaving in a polarised or contradictory way with different groups of residents. And this is the ultimate story to learn, that an institution can't be both disciplinarian and, let's say, indulgent.

11d. Measuring individual incapacity

P 80-81

The other thing which I'd like to quote is the method of measuring individual incapacity for self-care. We realised that a key factor in assessing residential care was the quotation from the National Assistance Act [that] the residential Homes were needed for people, were required for people "in need of care and attention". So it seemed to me obvious that if we were going to pronounce on the development of these places, were they really providing for people "in need of care and attention"? And it was quite obvious to me that a number of the residents, quite a lot of them, in fact, were not in need of care and attention, that either they had recovered from an episode of malnutrition in their own homes, let's say, or from a minor stroke where people thought they were never going to get any better and they did.

Or there were people who, though disabled in a minor way, were effectively being shunted out of their homes, either because a landlord had his eyes on possible profit, and this is a very important point to make, or because relatives were finding it increasingly difficult to visit, perhaps because they were coming from a long distance, or perhaps neighbours moved, or relatives had to move…. So, what I'm trying to say is that, for a variety of reasons, the infirmity of some of the people admitted to residential Homes was exaggerated, as it is today….

We gave a score - we covered a range of activities, and it wasn't just whether people could get up and down stairs, and get in and out of bed and wash and dress themselves, which is reasonably obvious, but it was also whether they could communicate in speech and hearing and writing, and how far their mobility could lead them, whether they could engage in conversation, and did so. Now, that was very important at the time, because it gave a kind of instrument by which to start saying, "Well, some of these people were very severely disabled, and oughtn't to be in a residential Home where they hadn't got basic nursing care by nurses who were qualified to give it, or doctors where it was needed". So at one end, you got people - a relatively small proportion, I may say - who really shouldn't be there, because they required more advanced basic nursing and medical care. Or at the other extreme, and the much larger number, who really, there was no particular reason why they should be in an old people's Home at all, and where, if we'd had the alternative of sheltered housing, might be better placed.

That instrument, therefore, tied up with both explanations, scientifically, but also policy, as well.

And that measure of incapacity for self-care, I'm pleased to say, was taken up in all sorts of places, overseas as well as in this country. It led eventually to - you can trace the steps - a lot of others contributed to this particular sequence of steps in modelling and improving and varying that kind of method. But it did end up with an international classification of disability, in a functional way, rather than in a medically originated way.

12. Poverty in the United Kingdom (1967-79)

P 102
That was a new plan of campaign, partly prompted by the discovery that pensioners weren't quite as well off as, maybe, the Welfare State developments after the War, had seemed to imply. There were one or two reports around the country about problems of people with low income, and who were disabled, or lone parents. I was invited to, and had been interested already in writing about poverty, and came to the conclusion that not enough attention was being called to not just the residues - because I wouldn't use that term, because I think it's a bit derisive - but there was more poverty still existing in Britain, than many people supposed. I felt that this deserved much more concerted attention. There were one or two papers prepared and produced during this period, but the main work began once we gained approval from The Rowntree Trust.

This started by deciding that, well, there were certain categories of poor people, who had not attracted much interest previously. The idea was that we'd take - oh, two or three years, maybe, to really prepare an original and creative national survey of the entire problem. And in the meantime, it would be a very good idea to look at some specific categories of people, or problems, as it's sometimes referred to. So we decided, a group of us - there was Adrian Sinfield, and then Dennis Marsden at the University of Essex, and Hilary Land who was working at the London School of Economics - we invited them, in particular, with John Veit Wilson, who subsequently worked from Newcastle, but we appointed him to the University of Essex. Each of them took over an area of interest: large families in Hilary Land's case; the unemployed in Adrian Sinfield's case; the sick and disabled in John Veit Wilson's case, and lone parents, Dennis Marsden. And they engineered research and reports. Of course, that's another quite substantial account. But at least two books emerged fairly quickly from that research: …, Mothers Alone, by Dennis Marsden, and Large Families in London, by Hilary Land….

It wasn't really until 1967 that the pilot of the National Survey was carried out, and the very elaborate questionnaire and arrangements for visiting different constituencies all round Great Britain were developed. So that work took place in 1967-68.

12a. Creative computing

P 109-110
I should also mention Phil Holden, who was a very patient computer programmer. I kept changing and developing lists of tables. One thing that's worth saying, for an audience who are caring about improving their own research prowess, is that [it's important that] you do get into computing a lot, and I hope people will do, because numbers matter, not only quality. He taught me quite a lot about the ways in which [I could achieve] something that I wanted to commission,

in terms of novel tables, of trying to select particular categories, and to devise new ways of generalising the information we were obtaining. He was extremely patient with me about all that. And, quite frankly, it's worth saying that, sometimes, if you think of a survey, of carrying out a set of interviews, and you want to calculate what per cent of people did this, and what per cent did that, I think you have to think of doing it in three stages.

Don't, for God's sake, develop a list of requests as long as your arm, when people will produce, you know, four feet deep of print-out. To wade through all that is almost an impossible job. Your best plan is to devise a short set of requests, to open up the subject, as it were, get the rough outline of the scope of a structure that you're investigating. Whether you're talking about different people in the population, for instance, if you're asking them about their occupation and their class, yes, everybody can think of the various ranks into which people will fit, and you need questions about the rank that people feel they occupy, as well as what that in their view means. And you can compare that with some sort of "objective" designations of what that means. But, in the first instance, you need to kind of get your information about what the shape of the sample, the people you've interviewed, what it looks like, where the majority of people put themselves. That's an obvious point, but sometimes you will find that 70 per cent of people put themselves in a particular category, and you've got to break that down into the second stage, and try and discover to what extent it's composed of certain sub-groups. That's an obvious point about going to a second stage.

But what I'm trying to say is that not only should you proceed like that in dynamic interchange with the programmer, if you don't do the programming yourself, but that you need to remember that you've got a third stage of being really creative with statistics. And by that I mean that in the process of carrying out a survey, you discover certain things about housing, or you discover certain things about political opinion, or things about disability, if you're any good, which hadn't occurred to you before hand. Part of the point about doing any research is to discover things you weren't quite aware of beforehand. And that will mean, sometimes, devising, putting groups together that you hadn't anticipated, to explore the results of doing that, and looking at gender, for example, in a new way. If suddenly you become aware that gender differences are not, perhaps, as covered as you'd like, and that you want to try and check a particular thesis or conclusion, it's almost like saying, if I dare put this, the first stage is the initial outline, the second stage is the follow-up into sub-categories, if you like, which is easy to understand. The third stage is the really creative stage where you are checking your conclusions, and that is a very important way of using statistics creatively, and sometimes changing what you thought about methodology in the first place, but also using your statistics to the hilt.

12b. Refusals

P 114-16

Could we start by talking about one problem in the survey. With the two studies that we've been talking about - the poverty and ageing ones - in both cases, you were concerned that you should always try very hard to interview people who were missing or who refused, initially, to be interviewed.

Yes. I think that, generally speaking, people engaged in research tend to fall into the

conventional trap of finding that if they get ten per cent, or 20 per cent refusals from people they are supposed to interview, this doesn't matter too much because the great majority have answered. And if they check on some very crude criteria of the distribution of age, or the distribution of occupation, that it roughly reflects the distribution in the population, that's all right.

But I learned, to my cost, first of all, really, in the studies of the elderly, that you were missing, even among a small percentage of refusals or non-contacts, people who really mattered when it came to generalisation. In the case of the elderly, what I say can be fairly obvious to a listener or to a reader, which is that there were clearly, among some of the people involved in the random samples that I applied, there were people who were confused, or so severely disabled, or sick on the particular days, that it was impossible to arrange an interview.

I then formed the idea that it was important, certainly in the case of the elderly, and especially the very old, to get proxy interviews. In other words, I'd noticed that during interviews, and this is very rarely reported, there are others present as well as the informant who is the particular subject of the interview. And I think research workers do not heed enough the variations in the answers they get when other people are present, compared with when just the single informant who is recorded, whose answers are recorded, is present… But, starting with the elderly, if one goes on to the problem of representation, it was quite clear to me that we were under-estimating the severely disabled, and the especially mentally disabled among them. And therefore I tried to counterbalance that to a certain extent, without quite appreciating how significant it was, numerically speaking.

That led me to believe that when we carry out interviews and sampling, it's extremely valuable to obtain as much information about those who are not present when you call at an address, or those who refuse, or, more likely, people who refuse on their behalf. Because it's usually, in those cases, a husband or a wife, or a mother or a father, or another relative who deters you from meeting the informant you want to address. So I began to develop this idea… In the end, I formulated a mini-questionnaire for the interviewer to complete. This obviously covered straightforward issues like the type of house, and the ownership of the house: which, in itself, would be quite fascinating to check against the achieved sample, compared with the intended sample. I added to this by putting in as much as possible, even thinking of what items might be helpful from a neighbour, items which were clearly not controversial or disputable, or in any sense confidential, but just how many people were there, what kind of age they were and who lived at that address, and anything, roughly, that coould be described about them, even to the extent of an occupation.

But that possibility seems to me capable of considerable development, and could easily be an extra item among the responsibilities of the interviewer to carry out. Now, I'm well aware that, in doing that, you have to be prepared for having just three or four or your 20 questions answered, rather than all 20, in terms of what information you can collect about the people who you have failed to obtain an interview from. But we did do this in the Poverty Survey, and I only regret that we didn't really make enough of it. I started, I remember, at the time, starting to put this together, and beginning to realise it was a kind of exercise in itself, but I wish I had

carried it out now.

Do you have some idea of who was, in particular, missing in the Poverty Survey?

Oh, it's a familiar story which comes from the Family Expenditure Survey… Namely that, at the top of the income distribution, the Family Expenditure Survey is singularly fluffy about the rich, and it's quite clear that they don't get a sufficient representation, nor are questions asked enough about the appropriateness of the questionnaire for some of the rich because, of course, a lot of the questions are almost beside the point, in terms of the way in which large pots of gold are managed…

But among the poor, it's been quite clear to me for many years, and this has been glossed over, frankly, by those administering the Survey, that the sick and disabled are greatly under-estimated, and the extreme elderly are under-estimated, generally speaking…And one could make the same point about what we know to be the case, a lot of younger people who sleep at different flats, and at their friends, and homes of their friends in order to get by, but are not considered homeless because they're not actually on the streets or trying to get into a hostel. We know this goes on among teenagers, and this is probably under-estimated… Another group that occurs to me, of course, are ethnic minorities… There are more unemployed people, therefore a little bit more of a mobile population, of family break-ups, and, therefore, not always quite certain about who is in the household and who isn't … So these are new features of the population, new elements in the population, that are not quite covered.

That brings me to argue that, yes,… we haven't really addressed how the changes in society and its structure, and its behaviour ought to affect the way in which those surveys are based.

13. Report on Georgia for UN

International fieldwork
P147-50
I was lucky enough to be appointed by the UNDP to visit Georgia at a time when there had been civil war, and the huge upheaval with liberalisation of the Republics, resulting from the Soviet Union. And I went in 1994, for only a very few weeks, and my role was a very subordinate one as part of an exercise intended to give advice about ways in which governance could be developed…

Let me just recount, briefly, the major influences as I saw them. There was first of all the discovery that Georgia was a highly civilised country, an admirable society in many different ways. I discovered that, and this applied to, up to a point, only very shortly before 1994, it applies up until the late 1980s, it had more doctors per thousand people than anywhere in the world, including the United States. It had more nuclear physicists, which is an ironic side. It had been Stalin's birthplace, and in some senses, therefore, had preferential treatment as one of the States of Russia, one of the regions of Russia. It had more musicians, architects, sculptors, artists, opera performances, than is easy to acknowledge. And for me, almost the single confirming point about the extent of its high culture, and its high civilisation, as well

as it's the most beautiful country, and has the most extraordinary panoply of treasures from the past, and of cultural continuities. Some of the music sung in some of the churches was just unbelievably beautiful…

And it is not only a beautiful country, with a highly developed and appreciative history, which is a living history and culture, but, as I say, again, people could find this ironic, but what I did find, to my amazement, was that it had the most generous social security system that I know anywhere in the world. It's pension scheme is more elaborate, or was more elaborate and more generous, than that in Sweden, for example…

The second thing was that there were people there who, as it were, treasured those institutions which were, who were being side-lined, and side-tracked, people who ought to have been at the very heart of the rebuilding and modernisation of Georgia who, because they were universalists, they were almost European in their stance, or internationalist. They were being side-lined in favour of those who were subservient to Westernisation and marketisation, and a get-rich-quick philosophy… quite frankly. So there's a very interesting story still to be told, about how it was

And thirdly, observations in Georgia… I was astonished at some of the things I saw… The Mafia is one significant point. Some of these Republics are ruled, in effect, by Mafia. Now, I'd learned a bit about the Mafia in Los Angeles. There are two gangs in Los Angeles who run large parts of the city centre, be it remarked, which we are not told very much about. But in some of these former Soviet Union territories, you have two kinds of Mafia… One was the former Soviet bosses of the Defence Ministry, in particular, and the Army, who were lining their pockets by using fleets of military lorries, army lorries, to deliver petrol from Turkmenistan to street corners in Tbilisi, in plastic cans, sold at exorbitant prices, or at the most exorbitant they could command, and this is a very sort of insidious form of corruption which was almost one of the throwbacks to Soviet authoritarianism.

The other Mafia was the get-rich-quick from Western markets, those who were selling Marlborough cigarettes and Coca Cola, or delivering them to kiosks. Because a lot of the shops were largely empty, because people couldn't afford to buy anything, and as a consequence of that, there were kind of entrepreneurial kiosks, and sales of goods and clothing, almost like our car boot sales, along the sides of the streets. And this Mafia, you could see them, I saw them two or three times in Tbilisi, of young men with machine guns thrown around their shoulders, zooming around in BMWs. Very few cars on the streets, I may say, but those cars often were in the hands of such figures, and these were, you know, very influential in the control, or so-called control, of Tbilisi. And the government, Sheradnadze and others still had major problems of the police obtaining control and not being corrupted in the process.

So these observations were important, but they included one which is worth recounting. I suddenly observed, going around the streets, that occasionally I saw one woman with a hen in a sack, under her arm, and strangely enough, I then saw another and another. Now, just one or two, I wouldn't have remarked upon, … but I saw this three or four times, and then asked

what it was. And I found this a very vivid and seminal story, that this old woman told the interpreter. [She] was taking it from place to place, she lived in a block of flats, and the only way in which she could subsist, live, day by day, was to find places where the hen could peck, so that it could lay an egg the following day…

In health, psychiatric hospitals and hostels, people were dying in them, because although some of the nurses had gone to extraordinary lengths to try to look after patients in conditions where they couldn't get food, where they couldn't get transport, where they couldn't get salaries. It's understandable that some nurses just pushed off and found something else to do, a few that survived tried to keep some of the patients going, but there were examples where people, because there was no system of care that could be kept in being, people were dying. A lot of this remains unreported. A lot that remains unreported is the high growth of mortality in those sort of territories, even worse in some other countries than Georgia…

Now, anyone coming along, as I did, into that situation, was liable to say, "Hey, look, you've got enormous human assets and resources here. You have a framework of delivery. For God's sake, in the transition period, do what you can to prop it up. Pour in some minimal resources, in order to finance primary health care, in order to finance the elderly" … These questions were not being addressed at all. The idea that was prevailing on the part of the IMF and World Bank delegations, and I met one delegation and had a stormy row with them, but their attitude was really that Communism had to be smashed, that nothing of the past was worth preserving. They adopted an extreme Friedmanite position of neo- monetary principles. Safety nets, even, had no part to play. And they had no ideas about the public sector, they only wanted to see more privatisation.